

Product Requirements Document (PRD)

1. Problem Statement

Restaurant operations — especially scheduling — are fragmented across multiple disconnected systems. Managers must manually coordinate staff schedules, availability, time-off requests, and shift changes while also reacting to unpredictable demand and employee call-outs.

This results in:

- Significant time spent managing schedules
- Last-minute staffing disruptions
- Difficulty coordinating employee availability
- Constant switching between multiple tools

The core problem is **operational coordination**: restaurant managers lack a simple centralized system to manage staff schedules, availability, and shift coverage in one place.

2. Product Vision

Create a **simple restaurant operations hub** that:

1. Automatically builds staff schedules
2. Lets employees manage availability and shift swaps
3. Helps managers anticipate staffing needs
4. Unifies operational data in one place

Key principle:

Reduce the owner's cognitive load while keeping the interface extremely simple.

3. Target Users

Primary User

Restaurant Owner / Manager

Needs:

- Quick scheduling
 - Staffing visibility
 - Labor cost control
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Secondary Users

Restaurant Employees

Needs:

- Easy availability updates
 - Shift swapping
 - Schedule visibility
 - Simple mobile interaction
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4. Platform Strategy

The initial version will be built as a **web-based platform** for fast deployment and testing.

Reasons:

- Faster development
- Easy iteration based on feedback
- Accessible from any device

If adoption and feedback are strong, the product can later be converted into a **native mobile app**.

5. User Interaction Model

Manager (Owner)

Primary interaction through:

- Desktop browser
- Tablet browser

Use cases:

- Generate weekly schedules
 - Approve shift swaps
 - Review staff availability
 - Monitor staffing coverage
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Employees

Employees interact primarily through **their phones**.

Ways they interact:

- Open the website from a phone browser
- Access a mobile-optimized interface
- Receive a link to view schedules or claim shifts

To improve accessibility, the website can function as a **Progressive Web App (PWA)** so employees can add it to their phone home screen and use it similarly to an app.

Employee actions:

- Submit availability
 - Request time off
 - View schedule
 - Claim open shifts
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6. Core Product Features

Feature 1: Smart Scheduling Assistant

Automatically generates a weekly schedule.

Inputs:

- Employee availability
- Historical staffing patterns

- Known busy periods
- Preferred worker pairings

Output:

A recommended weekly schedule managers can review and edit.

Capabilities:

- Drag-and-drop schedule editing
- Quick manual overrides
- Weekly auto-generation

Optional (AI Assistance)

Future optional insights could include:

- Recommended staffing levels
- Identifying under- or over-staffed shifts

These suggestions will appear only when explicitly requested to avoid overwhelming the manager.

Feature 2: Employee Availability Portal

Employees submit availability through a simple interface.

Employees can:

- Submit weekly availability
- Request time off
- View their schedule

Benefits:

- Eliminates scattered text messages
 - Centralizes availability data
 - Simplifies schedule creation
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Feature 3: Shift Swap Marketplace

When a shift becomes available:

1. The system notifies eligible employees.
2. Employees can claim the shift.
3. Manager approves with one click.

Benefits:

- Reduces last-minute texting
 - Encourages employee-driven shift coverage
 - Minimizes staffing emergencies
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Feature 4: Event & Demand Awareness

The system allows the manager to record or import known local events that affect restaurant demand.

Examples:

- Local events
- Holidays
- University breaks
- Graduation weekends

These events appear on the scheduling calendar to help managers anticipate staffing needs.

Optional (AI Assistance)

Optional demand insights could later include:

- Identifying historically busy periods
- Highlighting possible high-traffic events

These insights will remain optional to avoid excessive notifications.

Feature 5: Team Compatibility Tracking

Managers can record employee pairings that work well together.

Example tags:

- Works well together
- Avoid pairing
- Strong team combination

The scheduling interface highlights these relationships to help managers build more effective teams.

Feature 6: Unified Operations Dashboard

A single dashboard provides a quick overview of daily operations.

Dashboard displays:

- Today's staff schedule
- Upcoming shifts
- Open shifts needing coverage
- Pending time-off requests
- Known upcoming events

Goal:

Replace multiple operational tools with a **single centralized view** of staffing and scheduling.

7. MVP Scope

The first version will focus on core scheduling functionality.

Included in MVP

1. Weekly schedule builder
 2. Employee availability submission
 3. Shift swap system
 4. Manager dashboard
 5. Mobile-friendly employee interface
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Not Included in MVP

- Reservation system integration
- Inventory or ordering systems
- Marketing automation
- Advanced predictive analytics

The goal of the MVP is to **solve the scheduling coordination problem first**.